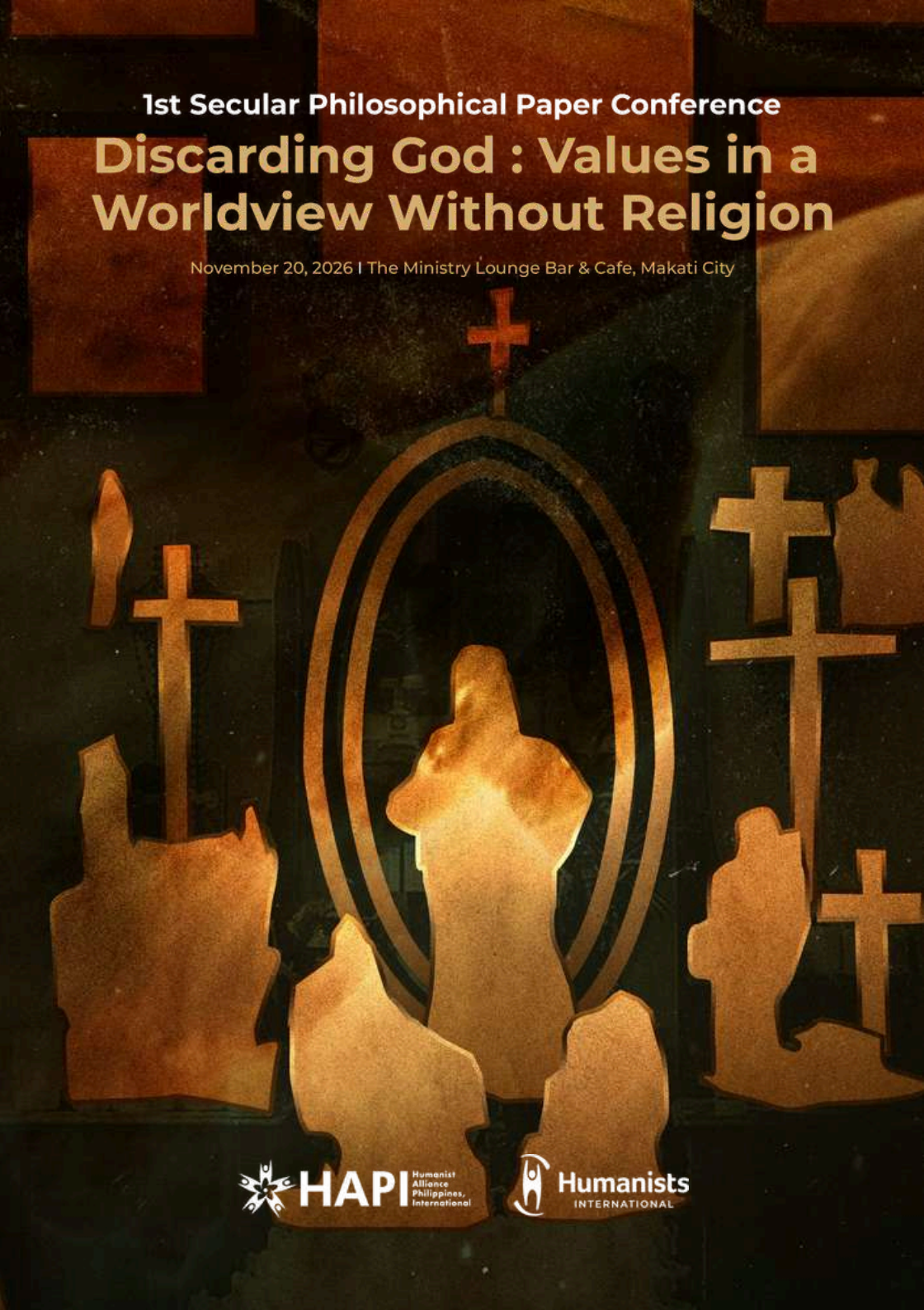
1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference

Discarding God : Values in a Worldview Without Religion

November 20, 2026 I The Ministry Lounge Bar & Cafe, Makati City



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November 20, 2026 | The Ministry Lounge Bar & Cafe, Makati City

PROGRAMME FLOW

9:00AM - 9:15AM	**Opening Remarks** Mark Jaztine Santos
9:15AM - 9:45AM	**Plenary Lecture** Prof. Darren Dumaop, PhD
9:45AM - 10:10AM	**Q&A Forum**

Parallel Session 1

10:30AM - 10:50AM	**Until We Rest: Exploring Augustine's Notion of Restlessness in Contemporary Life** Jazel Sevilla Panelist: Prof. Kim Ullero
10:10AM - 10:30AM	**Between Devotion and Seduction: Mysticism as a Technology of Female Authority in Catherine of Siena** Arabella Grace Sta. Ana Panelist: Prof. Kim Ullero
10:50AM - 11:10AM	**And God Gave Them Mouths: A Rancièrean Inquiry into Equality at the Limits of Theological Authority** Aron Malonzo Panelist : Prof. Kim Ullero
11:10AM - 11:30AM	**Q&A Forum**
11:30AM - 12:30PM	**Lunch Break**

Parallel Session 2

12:30PM - 12:50PM	**Of Religion, Morality, and Nietzsche** Joshua Rupert Buraga Panelist: Prof. Kim Ullero
12:50PM - 1:10PM	**Ontology and the Eternal Return in Nietzsche's Epicurean Sea and Ethics of Self-Cultivation** Jerome Mari Item Panelist: Prof. Kim Ullero
1:10PM - 1:30PM	**The Divine Hypocrisy: Morality Beyond Religion** Jonathan Rano Panelist: Prof. Joyce Fungo
1:30PM - 1:50PM	**Q&A Forum**

1:50 PM - 2:35PM	**Plenary Lecture** Prof. Joyce Estelle Fungo, PhD (cand.)
2:35PM - 2:45PM	**Q&A Forum**
2:45PM - 3:05PM	**Coffee & Bread Break**

Parallel Session 3

3:05PM - 3:25PM	**Hinges as necessary presuppositions for epistemic and semantic practices: Implications for humanism and faith** Apollo Gueco Panelist: Prof Joyce Fungo
3:25PM - 3:45PM	**A Language Without God: The Agency of Secular Ethics in the Void of the Divine** Ron Mangondato Panelist: Prof. Joyce Fungo
3:45PM - 4:05PM	**Hyperreal Atheism : The Simulation of God and the Death of Belief** Jhun William Cabrezos Panelist: Prof. Joyce Fungo
4:05PM - 4:25PM	**Q&A Forum**

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PROGRAMME FLOW

Parallel Session 4

4:25PM - 4:45PM	**"I Want Knowledge, Not Faith!": Epistemic Undetermination and the Search for the Divine in Ingmar Bergman's The Seventh Seal** Isiah Austin Angco Panelist: Prof. Joyce Fungo
4:45PM - 5:05PM	**When God Fell Silent: A Heideggerian Analysis of Nietzsche's 'Death of God** Edward Timothy Sotto Panelist: Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
5:05PM - 5:25PM	**"Mapupunta ka nga ba sa Impyerno?": The Notion of Huling Hantungan Through the Lens of Heidegger's Being-toward-Death** Marthie Valdueza Panelist: Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
5:25PM - 5:45PM	**Q&A Forum**

Parallel Session 5

7:40PM - 8:00PM	**Kapwa and The Ethics Of Responsibility: A Philosophical Understanding Through Gandhi's Dharma** Christian Johan Perez Panelist: Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
7:20PM - 7:40PM	**Lucidity, Revolt, and Passion: The Absurd Hero As A Secular Blueprint** Jason Zachary Gayoma Panelist: Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
8:00PM - 8:20PM	**Kiat: An Existential Reflection Of Trans Filipinx Becoming As A Movement** Kane Gaviola Panelist: Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
8:20PM - 8:30PM	**Q&A Forum**

5:45PM - 6:25PM	**Dinner Break**
6:25PM - 7:10PM	**Plenary Lecture** Prof. Chloe Nicole Piamonte
7:10PM - 7:20PM	**Q&A Forum**

8:30PM to 8:40PM	**Closing Remarks & Acknowledgements**
8:40 to 11:00PM	**Socialization, Networking & Fellowship** *(Optional)*

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DISCARDING GOD:

Values and Reason in a Worldview without Religion

THEME

By discarding God, what becomes of morality?

How would we account for reality and where do we get our purpose? Throughout history, religious dogma has often been used as a weapon to justify marginalizing whom the Scriptures condemn, suppressing skepticism and dissent, and reduce man into a fixed essence defined by the will of a particular conception of a deity. Organized religion was understood to be the ultimate basis of truth and judgment that must not be questioned.

The 1st HAPI Secular Philosophical Conference is the the first of its kind to bring together secular academics of philosophy and intellectuals of all disciplines from various universities to present and discuss secular perspectives on values, the existence of god, purpose, the origins of religion, and other like topics in a space specifically designated for freethinking and irreligion as a way of extending its representation in philosophical discourse.

The concept behind this is how secular humanist organizations and non-sectarian universities around the globe often hold philosophical conferences/congresses dedicated to secular ideas. This time, the Phiippines will now finally conduct its own.

WHAT TO EXPECT?

1. Food and beverages are included for the whole conference.
2. Participation and presentation is free
3. An amount of PHP 1,000 will be awarded to the authors of accepted abstracts "after" the presentation.
4. All authors will be given the opportunity to publish a 1000 word short-article version of their work to be published on HAPI's website.
5. Accepted abstracts will be encouraged (but not required) to submit their full manuscripts on international journals managed by secular humanist organizations such as 1) Secularism and Nonreligion, 2) Essays in the Philosophy of Humanism, and 3) Free Inquiry.

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1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference

About HAPI

Humanist Alliance Philippines International (HAPI) is a SEC registered not-for-profit secular humanist organization founded by Marissa Torres Langseth who was also the founder of PATAS or Philippines Atheists Agnostics and Secularists Society (though it is now managed by a different administration). Eventually, she took her attention from PATAS in December 2013 and founded HAPI so as to create a new avenue to spread humanism. HAPI was founded as a response against the excessive influence of religiosity over reasoning and morals in the Philippines.

Marissa, affectionately known to us as "Ms. M" and currently serving as Founder Emeritus on our Board of Trustees, built HAPI from the ground up out of a lifelong urge to give back. Growing up with humble beginnings in Cebu, she worked incredibly hard to earn her nursing degree before taking her healthcare career across Saudi Arabia and the United States, yet even as she built a successful life as an Adult Nurse Practitioner in New York, her heart remained deeply rooted in the Philippines. She provided the crucial seed money to get us off the ground and remains our biggest benefactor today, using her grit, generosity, and vision to keep HAPI moving forward and proving time and again that true morality is simply about humans helping humans. The organization campaigns for two primary causes: secularism and humanism.

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Our Story: Good Without a God

It starts with a simple idea: you don't need religion to be a good person. Welcome to Humanist Alliance Philippines, International (HAPI), where since our founding on December 25, 2013, we have been building a home for Filipino non-believers to connect, create, and care for our communities. We are a collective force pushing back against discrimination, poverty, and disinformation, and we are here to prove that compassion, ethics, and progress thrive perfectly well without a "godly" presence.

Our Roots: When Small Beginnings lead to Significant Impact

When our founder, Marissa Torres-Langseth, started HAPI, there were fewer than ten of us in the room, but we didn't let our small size stop us from taking immediate action. In those early days, we poured our energy into championing secular ideals through real-world events like community feeding programs in Alabang and public debates in Manila. We focused heavily on organizing secular talks, actively participating in Pride Marches from Baguio to the metro, and hosting vital sex education seminars and SOGIE talks. We even broke new ground by launching the Philippines' first-ever humanist animation series, proving that from day one, we have been laser-focused on gender equality, secular education, and stepping up for our communities when they needed it most.

Our Purpose: Growing Beyond Borders

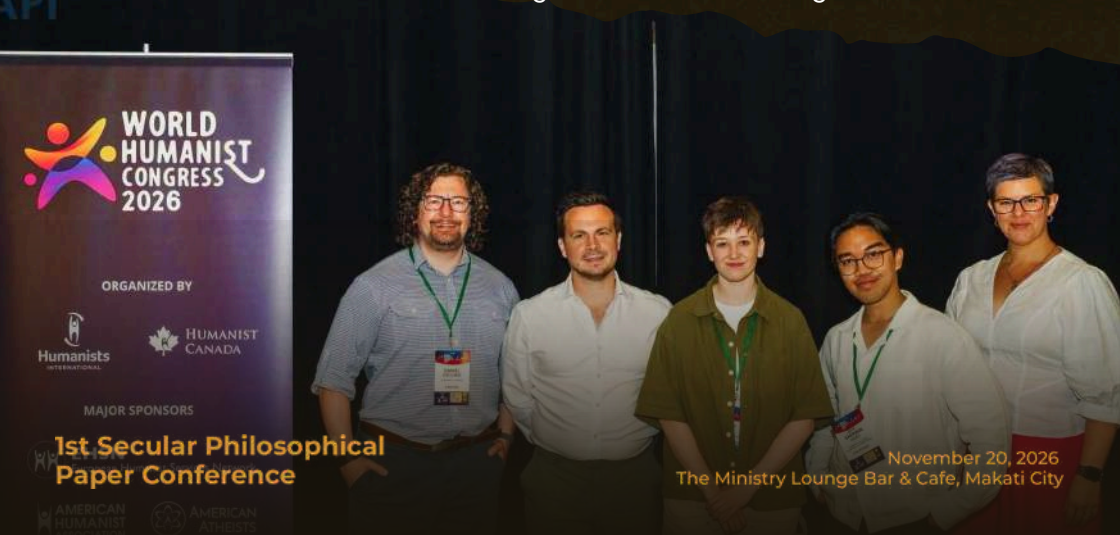
Today, HAPI operates through a highly collaborative national framework guided by our Board of Trustees and Executive Leadership. Our day-to-day advocacy is driven by dedicated divisions: Internal Operations & Management and Communications & Creative keep our internal engines running, while Programs & Outreach directly engages with the public. We also run specialized branches under our Special Departments, which proudly house the HAPI Scholars and our Philosophy Department. This unified structure empowers our officers and volunteers to create targeted, impactful solutions anywhere in the country, amplifying our global presence which has been proudly partnered exclusively with Humanists International since 2015.



By secularism, we engage in critical discourse regarding ideas that separate religion's clutches over reason and values. We do this through, but not limited to, our Cafe Humaniste sessions, online discussions on our Facebook Group, aparticipating in Humanist Congresses abroad, our own HAPI Conference, our upcoming humanist cell groups, and now, as we take it to the next level, through the pioneering and recurring Secular Paper Conference and HAPI's new department of philosophy. Through this practice, we aim to continue the same intellectual tradition of the thinkers and philosophers that shaped this organized secular movement. Hopefully, in the distant future, we aspire to be the center for the study of secularism in the Philippines and be able to manage our own secular philosophical and interdisciplinary journal to produce scholarly research on the study of irreligion.

By humanism, we do not wish to be stuck in intellectual contemplation and conversations. We practice our values and intellectual convictions to spread compassion and make the world a better place for humanity without anything in return and without appeal to a divine reward. We do this, through, but not limited to, volunteer & educational work, environmental drives, charity works towards grassroot and marginalized communities, pride events, among many others regardless if the recipients share our beliefs.

HAPI is a partner and member of Humanists International which is the global representative body of the humanist movement that unites a diverse community of non-religious/atheistic/secular organizations around the world. This conference is made possible through their support, particularly, with the generous Young Humanist Grant whose aim is to gather secular youths (ages 18-35) together in a space where they can openly and safely discuss irreligious ideas and worldviews to advance evidence-based thinking and freedom of thought.



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DID YOU KNOW?

These thinkers are part of the same organized secular humanist movement and intellectual tradition.

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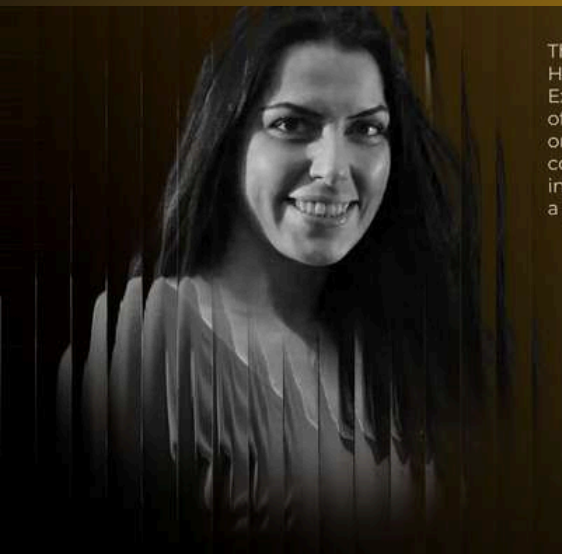
The analytic philosopher of religion and logician, **Bertrand Russell**, who was known for ideas such as Russell's teapot, theory of descriptions, theory of relations, axiom of reducibility and the barber paradox among many others was once a patron for and the vice president of British Humanist Association (now Humanists UK).



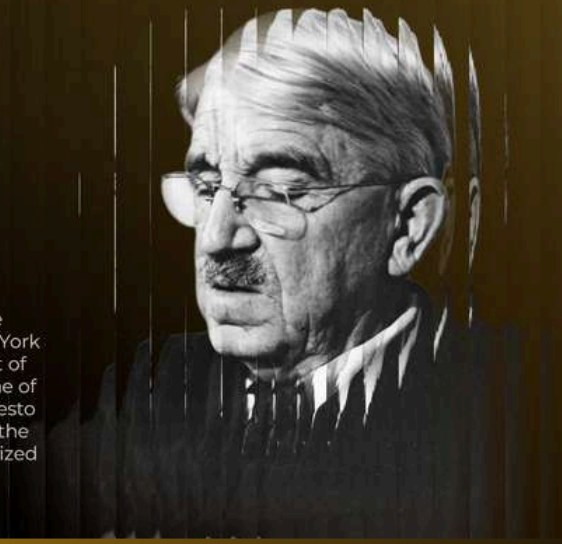
Albert Einstein, one of history's most prominent scientists who was known for his theories on general and special relativity, cosmological constant, Einstein field equations, unified field theory among many others, was a founding member of the First Humanist Society of New York, and an Honorary Associate of the Rationalist Press Association in the UK. He also co-authored the Russell-Einstein Manifesto alongside Bertrand Russell which is a call to abandon war as means of settliong disputes and the dangers of using weapons of mass destruction that could lead to humanity's extinction.

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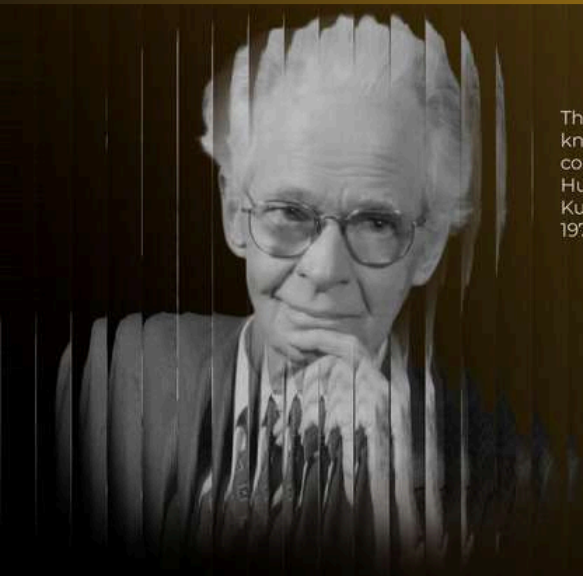
The biblical scholar from Oxford and professor of Hebrew Bible & Ancient Religion at The University of Exeter, **Francesca Stavrakopoulou**, who is the author of God: An Anatomy where she argued how the original and real god of the Abrahamic faiths had a concrete body and polytheistic origin as opposed to intangible and transcendent accounts of this deity - is a patron of Humanists UK and Defence Humanists.



John Dewey, a leading proponent of the school of thought known as pragmatism, was once part of the advisory board of the First Humanist Society of New York which was founded by Charles Potter with the intent of humanism being a religious organization. He was one of the original 34 signatories of the 1st Humanist Manifesto in 1933. He was also an elected honorary member of the Humanist Press Association which was later reorganized by Curtis Reese and John Dietrich to become the American Humanist Association.

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The atheist psychologist, **B.F. Skinner** who was known for radical behaviorism and operant conditioning, was one of the signers of the 2nd Humanist Manifesto that was co-authored by Paul Kurtz and was also named Humanist of the Year in 1972 by the American Humanist Association.



The philosopher of mind and one of the four horsemen of atheism, **Daniel Dennett**, who is also the author of a number of philosophical works such as Consciousness Explained, Breaking the Spell, Freedom Evolves, and Darwin's Dangerous Idea, served as a fellow of Committee for Skeptical Inquiry, an honorary board member of Freedom from Religion Foundation, and was named Humanist of the Year in 2004 by the American Humanist Association.

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AC Grayling, a prominent philosopher who authored many books on secular humanism and philosophy of religion. His works include The God Argument, Against All Gods, To Set Prometheus Free, and The History of Philosophy. He currently serves as one of the Vice Presidents of Humanists UK and one of the speakers at the World Humanist Congress 2026 in Ottawa, Canada.



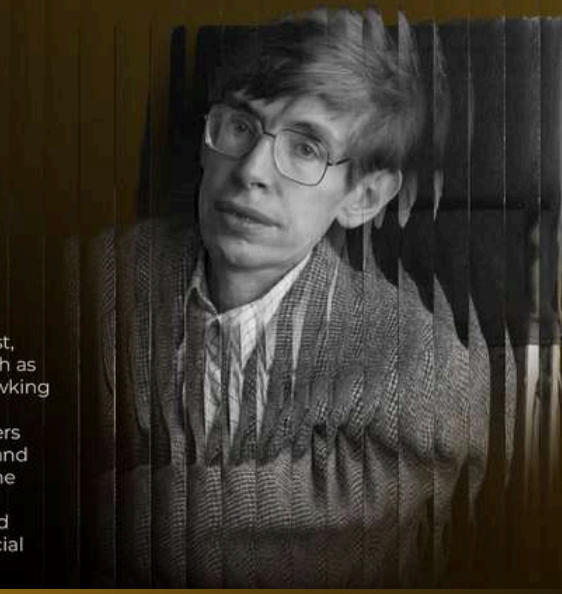
The moral philosopher/contemporary ethicist, **Peter Singer**, who was the author of Animal Liberation and known for his ideas such as -speciescism, equal consideration of interests, drowning child analogy, argument from marginal cases. and personism - is deeply involved with the secular humanist movement. He was appointed as a Humanist Laureate by the International Academy of Humanism and was also named Australian Humanist of the Year in 2004 by the Council of Australian Humanist Societies.

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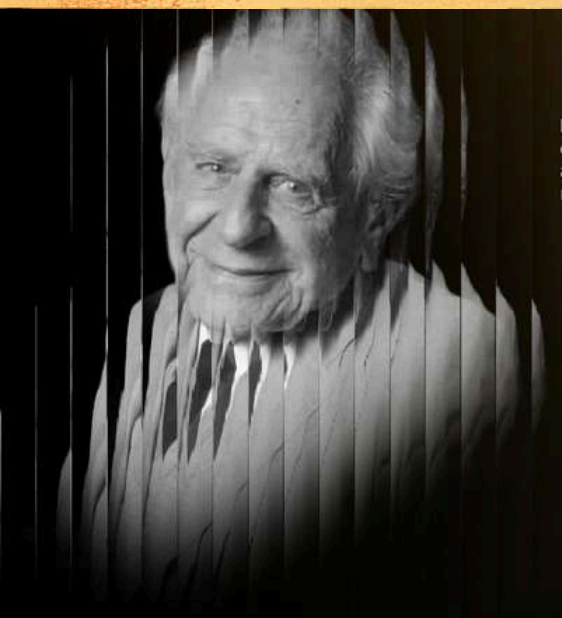
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The evolutionary biologist, **Julian Huxley**, who has known for modern synthesis, served as the first president and one of the founders of Humanists International who proudly supports and sponsored this conference in the present.



Prominent theoretical astrophysicist and cosmologist, **Stephen Hawking**, who was known for his ideas such as Hawking radiation,, Penrose Hawking theorems, Hawking energy, primordial black hole, micro black hole, and chronology protection conjecture among many others and authored books such as A Brief History of Time and The Universe in a Nutshell, was actively involved in the secular humanist movement since he was an undergraduate student at Oxford through the Oxford University Humanist Group. He also serves as an official patron of Humanists UK during the 2000s.



Karl Popper, a philosopher of science known for his concept of fasificationism as a criterion that sets apart the sciences from pseudoscience, is a member of the advisory council of Humanists UK.



One of the founding fathers of secular humanism, **Paul Kurtz**, who was known for his notion of Eupraxophy is a co-author of the 2nd Humanist Manifesto which insisted that secular humanism should not be perceived as a secular religion. He was the founder of Prometheus Books and Center for Skeptical Inquiry. He was a former editor of American Humanist Association's Humanist Magazine.



Rebecca Goldstein, a prominent philosopher who authored Betraying Spinoza, Incompleteness, Plato at Googleplex, The Mind-Body Problem, and now, The Mattering Instinct has also been named the Humanist of the Year by the American Humanist Association and Free-thought Heroine by the Freedom from Religion Foundation. She earned her PhD in Philosophy at Princeton University with a concentrate in philosophy of science and philosophy of mind. where she studied with Thomas Nagel and wrote a dissertation titled "Reduction, Realism, and the Mind." She is a member of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences and is visiting Professor of Philosophy at New College of the Humanities in London.

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MEET THE

FACILITATORS AND STAKEHOLDERS

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JAZTINE SANTOS

MASTER OF CEREMONIES, PROJECT HEAD
CHIEF OF ACADEMIC AFFAIRS

Jaztine Santos is the project head and the master of ceremonies of the 1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference sponsored by Humanists International through the Young Humanist Grant. He took his undergraduate degree in Philosophy at the Polytechnic University of the Philippines and graduated with a grade of 1.16. He is currently taking his Master's degree in Philosophy at Ateneo de Manila University. His research interests and intended areas of specialization are philosophy of religion and the occult, phenomenology and existentialism, academic theology, analytic metaphysics (particularly of time travel), and metaethics. Outside the academia, he loves making espresso as a barista and making covers with his piano, vocals, and violin. He is also obsessed with music that evokes nostalgia with heavy synths, pads, and reverbed beats which made him a fan of Nightly, Fly By Midnight, LANY, WOAH, Hazlett, and Chezile. As a secular humanist, he is currently serving as the Chief of Academic Affairs of HAPI's Philosophy Department - Secular & Existential Philosophies and a regular web writer as a HAPI Scholar.

SHANE HARO

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, HAPI

Shane Haro is Chief Executive Officer of Humanist Alliance Philippines, International. After earning his AB in Communication Arts from the University of Santo Tomas, he pursued a Master's in Bilingual and Multicultural Education at the Instituto Franklin–Universidad de Alcalá in Madrid.He most recently represented the organization at the World Humanist Congress 2026. Last year, he addressed the United Nations on Freedom of Expression in the Philippines. Across his seven years of humanist advocacy, he has overseen the publication of hundreds of Filipino humanist stories and thinkpieces on the HAPI website. As Chief of the HAPI Scholars, he oversees the training of young humanist writers and artists from across the Philippines, drawing on their creativity to help promote humanism among Filipino youth. Through their help, he produced the Philippines' first-ever humanist animation series. He has an unusual obsession with pop culture, and could probably slay pop culture trivia night with you.





KELLY KIM SEPIDA

ART DIRECTOR, HAPI

Kelly Kim F. Sepida is HAPI's Art Director and the official graphic artist of the 1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference. He is responsible for the aesthetic visuals of HAPI, of the publication materials of the event posted in our social media platforms, and of the merchandise - particularly, the conference booklet. He graduated summa cum laude with a degree on Architectural Drafting at Carlos Hilado Memorial State University - Talisay (Main) Campus. Beyond his design work, he enjoys binge-watching animated and horror films.

ANNIKA PALAGANAS

SOCIAL MEDIA DIRECTOR

Annika Palaganas is the Social Media Director of HAPI. She is the brains behind HAPI's social media strategy in general and for promoting and disseminating information on the 1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference to ensure that it gains maximum visibility. She graduated cum laude with a Bachelor's degree on Organizational Communication at the University of the Philippines - Manila. In her free time she enjoys going to the gym, reading and writing.



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DARREN E. DUMAOP, PHD

PLENARY LECTURER

Darren E. Dumaop, PhD is an Associate Professor of Psychology and Associate Dean of the College of Liberal Arts at De La Salle University, where he serves as the inaugural Director of the Conflict in Religion Psychology Research Laboratory. He holds a PhD in Psychology, major in Social Psychology and minor in Personality, from the University of the Philippines Diliman. His research examines religious pluralism, religious conflict and its relationship with identity and agency, and prejudice against and mental health among Filipinos with secular identities. He is a former Chair of the Social Psychology Division of the Psychological Association of the Philippines and former Vice President of the Pambansang Samahan sa Sikolohiyang Pilipino. He is an alumnus of the UCSIA Summer School (Antwerp, Belgium) and a fellow of the Religion and Public Life in the Philippines Program sponsored by the British Academy. His current work focuses on religious pluralism and spiritual agency, and he pioneered the undergraduate teaching of Psychology of Religion and Spirituality at De La Salle University. Despite his otherwise boring academic profile, Darren enjoys comedy, often to the point of attempting a joke and eventually becoming the joke himself. He also considers himself a bit of a Bible geek, although this expertise has yet to translate into consistent victories in social media debates with random Jesus fans.

MEET THE

SPEAKERS

JANFLOR MC.LOUIE S. ULLERO

PANELIST

Janflor Mc.Louie S. Ullero is an Associate Professor of Philosophy at the School of Arts and Sciences, NU Fairview. He earned his Bachelor of Arts and Master of Arts degrees in Philosophy from the University of Santo Tomas, where he is currently pursuing his Doctor of Philosophy degree. His doctoral research reexamines John Rawls's theory of justice in light of the ethical, political, and environmental challenges of the Anthropocene. His teaching and research interests span political philosophy, social justice, environmental ethics, human rights, peace education, humanism, and AI ethics. He is particularly interested in how philosophical inquiry can address questions of justice, human dignity, moral responsibility, and the place of human beings in a rapidly changing social and technological world. His interest in humanism extends to questions concerning secular ethics, moral life outside traditional religious frameworks, and the role of reason and critical inquiry in public life. He is also a Research Fellow at the Critical Research Association Melbourne and is affiliated with various national and international philosophical and research organizations. His scholarly work includes "Rawls' Theory of Justice and the Social Challenges of the Pandemic in the Philippines," published by Brill. In February 2026, he received support from the British Academy to participate in an Early Career Researcher Workshop on Human Rights Education and Activism in Southeast Asia at Chiang Mai University, Thailand. He was also among the signatories and contributors to the 2025 Bangkok Declaration on the Social, Legal and Ethical Issues of Artificial Intelligence. Outside academia, he enjoys traveling and experiencing different cultures. For him, exploring new places is also an opportunity to encounter different ways of living, thinking, and understanding the world beyond the classroom.



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JOYCE ESTELLE S. FUNGO

PLENARY LECTURER & PANELIST



Joyce Estelle S. Fungo is an Assistant Professor of Philosophy at the University of the Philippines-Baguio and a PhD candidate at the School of Divinity, History, Philosophy, and Art History in the University of Aberdeen, supervised by Luca Moretti (University of Eastern Piedmont, Italy) and Federico Luzzi (University of Aberdeen, Scotland). Her course offerings in philosophy more recently have been in Special Questions in Ethics, Epistemology, and Metaphysics. Her academic interests rest in theories of knowledge and value and inquire into the enabling capacities of theory to better understand injustice and oppression in practice. Her hobbies shift at about the same rate as her moving from one place to another. But in various circles here and abroad, she's often found herself in board game communities, some in casual dungeons and dragons circles, and at one point in a medieval history gathering. And I guess like everyone else these days, she occasionally plays pickleball. She believes in finding ways to approach ideological differences, including religious differences, through self-reflexivity and intellectual humility – two traits she herself struggles with but continually aspires to practice.

MEET THE

SPEAKERS



CHLOE NICOLE D. PIAMONTE

PLENARY LECTURER & PANELIST

Chloe Nicole D. Piamonte teaches philosophy at the Polytechnic University of the Philippines (PUP) and the Ateneo de Manila University (ADMU). She also serves as the Chief of PUP's Center for Social Inclusivity Studies where she leads funded research on gender, diversity, and inclusivity. Her commitment to the unimaginable weight of teaching at two different institutions, and doing research, is deeply motivated by ensuring that she is too exhausted to be knocked out by existential crisis. (Also, one pays rent and the other buys maintenance meds.) Most of Chloe's days are spent either on these pretentious academic initiatives or in the classroom convincing students that existential humanism is real philosophy. She likes to believe that the latter is crucial as a personal validation that specialising in the philosophical approaches of phenomenology and existentialism is still relevant. Her days off are spent playing games to justify her impulsive purchase of a handheld computer, visiting her psychiatrist and her surgeon (the "real" doctor), hospital confinement, or at home staring at the shameful pile of her moldy unread books. A friend once told her that her toxic trait is loving Heidegger.

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MEET THE PRESENTERS

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ACCEPTED
PAPER ABSTRACTS

1st Secular Philosophical Paper Conference

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Between Devotion and Seduction: Mysticism as a Technology of Female Authority in Catherine of Siena

Arabella Grace Sta. Ana
Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy, University of the Philippines Los Banos

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Abstract

Between Devotion and Seduction: Mysticism as a Technology of Female Authority in Catherine of Siena

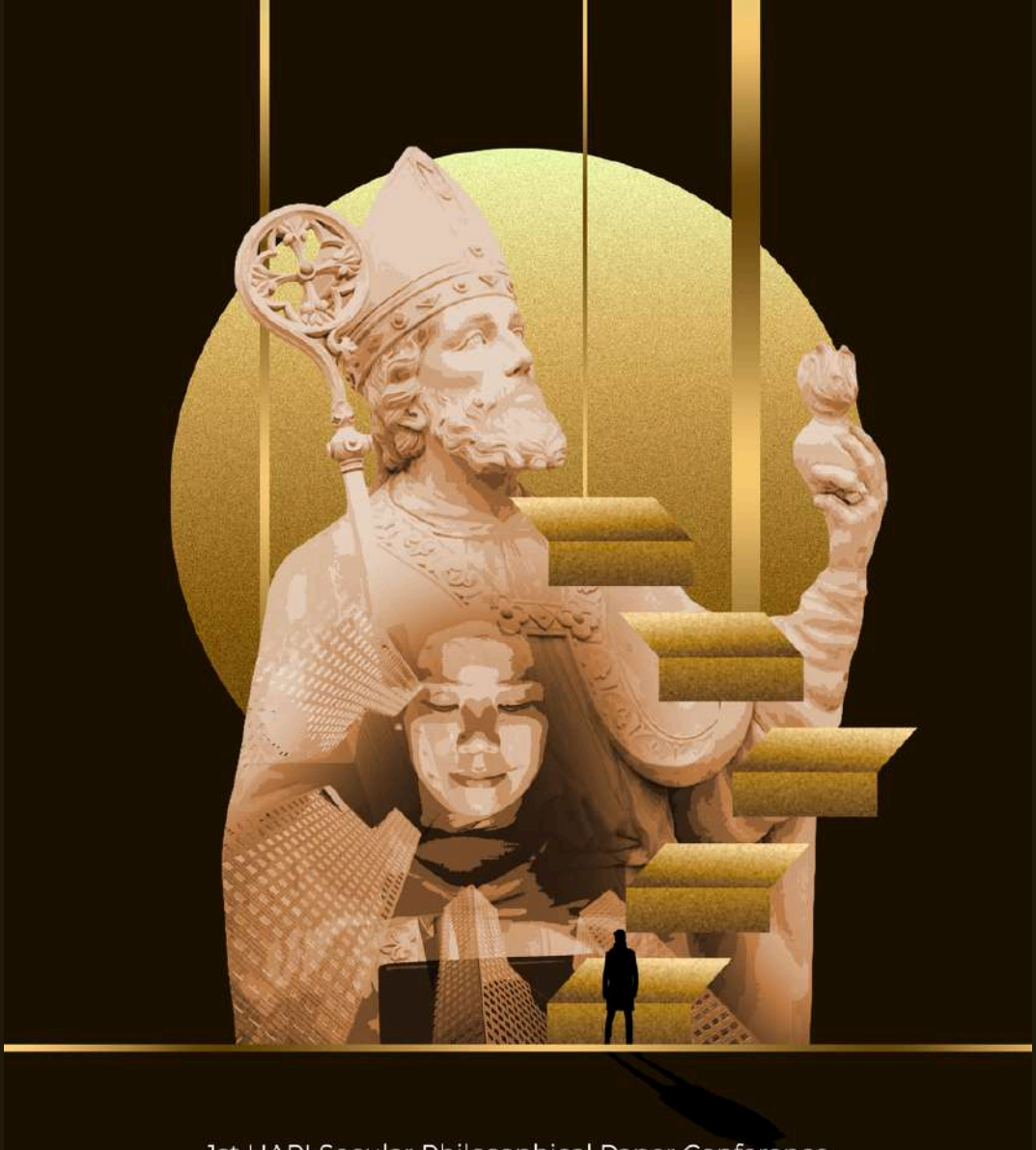
Arabella Grace Sta. Ana
Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy
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St. Catherine of Siena is one of the most beloved and controversial saints in the Church. Her mystical texts, filled with vivid references to Christ's blood and her visions of Him as the Bridegroom, provoke more profound discussions regarding the nature of religious desire. In certain contemporary interpretations, these experiences are perceived as manifestations of suppressed sexuality within a restrictive religious framework. But instead of viewing these experiences as signs of medieval repression, what if Catherine's suffering and obedience were not imposed, but chosen—even erotically desired? And more importantly, what if the question of whether her desire was "real" matters less than what that desire made possible for her? In this paper, I set aside the theological question of authenticity and argue instead that Catherine reconfigures obedience, suffering, and virginity into a strategy for gaining the kind of public authority that the Church otherwise refused to give women. Rather than being purely affective, her mysticism is epistemic and political, a method of gaining insight into God through the body that doubled as her only credential for theological speech. In a Church that largely excluded women from doctrinal authority, Catherine's wounds, hunger, and tears became the language through which she claimed the right to speak. Drawing on Fudgé's account of mysticism as a "deliberate strategy" for communicating spirituality and Sperling's work on how eroticized devotional imagery made divine intimacy understandable to others, I situate Catherine alongside Mechthild of Magdeburg and Julian of Norwich to trace a broader pattern of women turning bodily suffering into a source of authority. Thus, this paper does not ask whether Catherine's ecstasy was repression or genuine encounter, but what her erotic-mystical register accomplished for a woman writing from inside a structure built to silence her.

Keywords: mysticism, gender and religious authority, embodiment, medieval Christianity, power and discourse



Arabella Grace Sta. Ana is a BA Philosophy student at the University of the Philippines Los Baños, set to graduate in 2026. Her research interests lie primarily in philosophy of religion, feminist philosophy, and epistemology, particularly how embodiment, gender, and religious tradition intersect with questions of knowledge and authority. She is currently completing her undergraduate thesis on Marian devotion in the Philippines as a form of hermeneutical displacement, drawing on Fricker, Scheler, and Ricoeur, under the advisership of Sir Angelo. She has previously presented papers at the PHAVISMINDA 2025 Conference in Davao and the 5th PCC Conference in Silang, Cavite. She identifies as agnostic and approaches questions of religion primarily as sites of power, meaning, and epistemic negotiation. Outside of academic work, she plays bass guitar, rides a skateboard, and works as a freelance writer.



1st HAPI Secular Philosophical Paper Conference

Until We Rest: Exploring Augustine's Notion of Restlessness in Contemporary Life

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HAPI Humanist Alliance Philippines, International

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Abstract

Until We Rest: Exploring Augustine's Notion of Restlessness in Contemporary Life

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In Augustine's Confessions, he declared, "You have made us for Yourself, O Lord, and our hearts are restless until they rest in You." This statement articulates the human condition in the pursuit of pleasure, honor, and knowledge longing for something deeper, more abiding, and more eternal. In this paper, I explore Augustine's notion of restlessness by looking at three interrelated perspectives. First, I examine the philosophical foundations of Augustine's standpoint by situating his understanding of humans created teleologically for God. Second, I turn to the fulfillment of his orientation where love is being directed rightly, bringing us in the comfort of right order and spiritual rest. Third, I highlight the backdrop of modern restlessness in the pursuit of authenticity by turning to the contemporary philosopher, Charles Taylor, to analyze Augustine's account in contemporary life. Hence, I posit that although Augustine's sense of restlessness can be viewed as an articulation of metaphysical longing it continues to be redirected towards the present forms of human dissatisfaction and the question of genuine fulfillment. Ultimately, it invites further exploration of philosophical inquiry analyzing the Augustinian thought, the scholastic tradition and their place in secular contemporary conception of human desire and fulfillment.

Keywords: Augustine, restlessness, metaphysical longing, secularization, human fulfillment



Jazel Sevilla is a Senior student taking up BA Philosophy at the University of the Philippines - Los Baños. His interests in philosophy are speculative philosophy, epistemology, and Filipino philosophy. Despite being raised in a conservative environment, he learned to question and be critical on many stances of his religious affiliation such as: how life should be lived, what morals and principles we should cultivate, and the likes. Currently, he is writing his undergraduate thesis and hopes to finish it on-time. Beyond philosophy, he enjoys taking care of his six cats and loves baking banana loaf.



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And God Gave Them Mouths: A Rancièrean Inquiry into Equality at the Limits of Theological Authority

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Abstract

And God Gave Them Mouths: A Rancièrean Inquiry into Equality at the Limits of Theological Authority

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What becomes of equality once God is no longer its guarantor? In approaching this problematic, I turn to biblical narratives in which those occupying subordinate positions interrupt the partition that determines who may speak, who may be heard, and who may count. Read through the political philosophy of Jacques Rancière, figures such as the Syrophoenician woman and Bartimaeus appear at the point where an assigned place is exceeded by the subject who speaks from it. Their speech opens a problem within the theological imaginary itself: whether equality is something bestowed by an authority, or whether it is already presupposed in the capacity to speak. I argue (i) that these narratives harbor a conception of equality that unsettles their own theological ground. The excluded subject does not await the authorization of equality; she speaks from its presupposition—interrupting the place assigned by the existing order and rendering that place the site of its contestation. I then argue (ii) that this instability bears directly upon the question of ethics after God. Once transcendence is withdrawn as the ground of equality, what remains is the demand equality places upon subjects themselves. The ethical relation emerges without final authorization, sustained through the claim that those who appear without a place nevertheless appear as equals. Biblical narrative therefore becomes a site from which to reconsider whether equality requires a transcendent guarantee at all, and whether ethics can persist as a relation among equals once the authority that purportedly grounds their equality has been discarded.

Keywords: Rancière; equality; biblical narrative; theological authority; subjectification; secularism; ethics



Aron Malonzo is a Political Science student at National University – Clark whose research inhabits the intersections of political philosophy, critical theory, and the philosophy of religion. His work is informed by Jacques Rancière, Karl Marx, Louis Althusser, Antonio Gramsci, and the broader traditions of continental political thought. His research concerns state theory, equality, ideology, and political subjectification, with particular attention to their manifestations within Philippine political discourse. He has presented research at the 2026 Philippine Political Science Association Conference, the 2026 Philosophical Association of the Philippines Conference, and other academic conferences and forums, with work engaging Rancièrean political theory and the Philippine Left. Outside academia, he reads widely in philosophy, political theory, and literature and plays classical piano.

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Of Religion, Morality, And Nietzsche

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Abstract

Of Religion, Morality, And Nietzsche

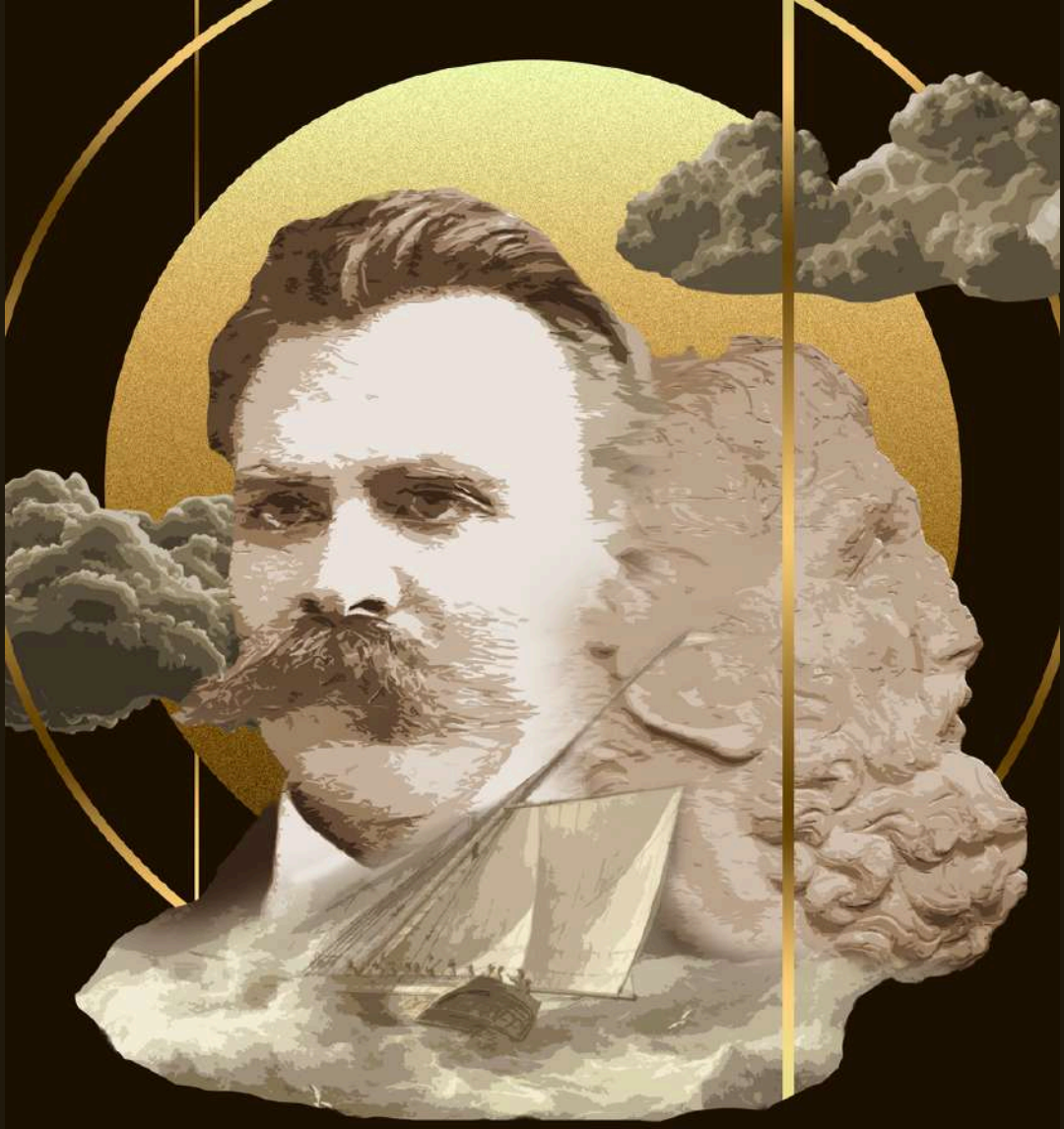
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In *On the Genealogy of Morals*, Nietzsche demonstrates through the (3) three concepts of master and slave morality, ressentiment, and ascetic ideals that these conditions signify and point toward the possibility of self-overcoming. Towards the three concepts aforementioned these are a cancellation of life, a life-denying in the position and situation of the herd, the plebeian, or the slave; and a beneficial, advantageous on the hands of the noble, few, and high-stationed men – the master. Hence, it is to show first that the concept ressentiment and ascetic ideals are developed within the morality of the master and slave. However, the morality of the slave is later concretized by the asceticism (or, ascetic ideal) developed and sustained by the Ascetic Priest which leads the slave to endure the idea of ressentiment. Moreover, it is also the intent of the study to locate the origin of morality and how it is then developed further. I will argue then in favor of Nietzsche that these are not a dead-end to the slave. Indeed, it refers to something. It is a means, an instrument, signaling to transcendence. I will use a hermeneutical framework in attempt to read, interpret, and to immerse in Nietzsche's texts in pursuing emphatic and intimate dialogue with the philosopher, his concepts, and to draw from the context. Through this, the study will demonstrate that morality should be a life-affirming, not a negation, and more importantly, to turn the asceticism and ressentiment into the subject of reconstruction of values that will no longer accommodate and acknowledge a life-denying values.

Keywords: Friedrich Nietzsche, Master and Slave Morality, Ressentiment, Ascetic Ideal, Life-affirming, Overcoming.



Joshua Rupert Buraga is an undergraduate, taking Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy in Polytechnic University of the Philippines, Sta. Mesa, Manila. His research interests, as an undergraduate, surrounds in moral philosophy. He's now in his senior year, working on a thesis and philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche and it is entitled: "Friedrich Nietzsche's Critique of Morality: Towards Overcoming Through the Master and Slave Morality". He is not mere imprisoned in philosophy. He has an interest in studying literature. Reading literature for him develops his philosophical activity of understanding social pathologies, to use philosophical discipline in social reality. Joshua believes philosophy without literature will fall under the abstract understanding of social reality.



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Ontology and the Eternal Return in Nietzsche's Epicurean Sea and Ethics of Self-Cultivation

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Abstract

Ontology and the Eternal Return in Nietzsche's Epicurean Sea and Ethics of Self-Cultivation

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I present Friedrich Nietzsche's ontology and the eternal return both from an Epicurean descent and their subsequent roles in his ethics of self-cultivation, ultimately elucidating his musings on the sea. Nietzsche was most perplexed confronting precisely what birthed religions, that is, life; particularly, on suffering, chance, and the horrors of existence. His task was to aptly position philosophy relative to the development of his ideas on the pain of becoming. In the middle period of Nietzsche's short academic stint (1878-1882), he deployed an Epicurean mode of thinking most prominently featured by Keith Ansell-Pearson. I argue, however, that we can also find an unconscious Epicurus in Nietzsche's unpublished notebooks after the publication of The Birth of Tragedy (1872). I depict Nietzsche's portrait of Epicurus in three (3) ways. (1) First, after the death of God, the question of Nietzsche's naturalism becomes the lens with which reality, life, change, and becoming are seen. It is from this grounded ontology that pleasure, the heroic-idyllic, and the closest things are regarded against the grip of transcendentalism. (2) I, then, examine the ways in which the eternal return must be construed; specifically, from the view of naturalism. This ethical reading, differentiated from a cosmological one, entails the problematization of disposition: how one might react to the thought. In this aphorism, Nietzsche is seen polarizing a person's reaction to the ethical challenge, irking one to fundamentally scrutinize one's own life and thinking. (3) Lastly, primed by Nietzsche's naturalism, I present his image of the sea as life, one riddled with the terrors of the uncharted and the vicissitudes of tides. This reading is compounded by his metaphor of circumnavigation, directed by the thought of the eternal return, leading one's life as their very own. These figures appear simultaneously or in the same works as Nietzsche's mentions of Epicurus, centralizing his importance in the former's corpus. As such, I demonstrate that an understanding of reality reorients one's outlook, post death of God, to see the world as a vast sea wherein one circumnavigates one's own ship, deeply informed by the eternal return.

Keywords: Nietzsche, Epicurus, naturalism, ontology, eternal return, the sea, circumnavigation



Jerome Mari S. Item is a student at the Graduate School of the University of Santo Tomas (UST) currently taking his Masters in Philosophy. His research interests are in Nihilism, Social Ontology, Aesthetics, and Ethics. In particular, his main bulk of research has been specialized around Friedrich Nietzsche, spanning from conditional Nihilism and Ontology to a philosophical and metaphilosophical critique of Transhumanism. He has presented these in at least ten different conferences across the Philippines where he met and joined various philosophical organizations and communities among many different schools. In his free time, most of the activities he involves himself in always include some form of socialization, from playing video games, to card games, and even playing music. It is easier to label himself as an atheist rather than explaining his indifference from belief. This, for him, irks one to be more cautious of their life and find one's own way of embracing amor fati.

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The Divine Hypocrisy: Morality Beyond Religion

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Abstract

The Divine Hypocrisy: Morality Beyond Religion

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This study examines the state of morality in a worldview without organized religion. This paper examines morality– wherein from a traditional sense– grounded on the divine, and what remains of moral experience when the divine can no longer offer a unique ethical standard. Central to this paper is the concept of moral judgement and how it operates through its underlying process. This paper analyzes how morality extends its consideration towards what is personally appealing while completely overlooking what does not. This pattern was observed through human behaviour, such as how some people operate in a selective extension of kindness based on appeal, relationship, rather than need. In line with this, this paper also considers that within these religious narratives on the basis of favor, mercy, and judgement, rather than treating the divine as an independent being and a justifier of a moral action, this paper considers divine as a reflection of humanity's own nature. Suggesting that such instances of inconsistency within religious conceptions of morality may be understood as behaviours already present in humanity. When humanity accepts that there is no one to blame regarding moral judgement but themselves alone, this paper calls for a greater take of personal responsibility of one's own action. This paper also analyzes that the divine hypocrisy in which moral judgement influenced by human will, is nonetheless assumed to be justified by the divine. In its concluding section, this paper considers the implication of this analysis regarding moral judgement beyond religious basis. Examining what may be lost and what may remain unchanged once the divine morality can no longer operate.

Keywords: Moral judgement, humanity, divine, behaviour, hypocrisy



Jonathan Raño is a 4th year undergraduate student in Polytechnic University of the Philippines and is currently taking Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy. His philosophical interests falls on religion, ethics, and humanity. His past research tackles the philosophy of death, and the concept of solitude. Outside academia, he is agnostic, usually seen outside having discussions with religious people. His hobbies are sports, paintings and gardening.

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Hinges as Necessary Presuppositions for Epistemic and Semantic Practices: Implications for Humanism and Faith

Apollo Kristoffe F. Gueco
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Abstract

Hinges as necessary presuppositions for epistemic and semantic practices: Implications for humanism and faith

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In this paper, I look at the prospects of interpreting both humanism and faith as containing necessarily presupposing propositions called 'hinges' that are necessary to constitute and regulate their worldviews, thereby propping up their entire edifice of reasons. Hinges, following Wittgenstein's On Certainty, have been interpreted as non-doxastic propositions (neither truth-apt nor justification-apt), yet are necessary for any cognitive agent's propositional attitudes to become truth-apt and justification-apt. This has been called the framework reading of hinges. In short, hinges are necessary presuppositions that make possible all our human cognitive capacities, i.e., having ontological and axiological priority over them. This implies that hinges can make both faith-based and reason-based worldviews and unmake them by their disruption. Thus, per Duncan Pritchard, both have parity and are arational at their foundations (i.e., one need not have reasons for trusting the ground one stands on yet it keeps one standing, until one fails to trust it and experiences a kind of epistemic vertigo). In other words, there is no superiority between worldviews. Contra Pritchard, I propose a way to assess how one could differentiate between hinges presupposed by both worldview-types. We can indirectly assess whether edifice of reasons for discarding or not discarding God are virtuous or not by reasons qua entitlements (here I use Jakob Ohlhorst's account applied to hinges). The paper is structured as follows: Pritchard's parity argument and what epistemic trouble it spell for those who hold superior their worldview (§1), the framework reading and a defense of entitlements as complements to hinges (§2), how to assess between hinges of faith and non-faith using entitlements (§3), anticipated objections (§4), and conclusion (§5).

Keywords: hinges, entitlements, Wittgenstein's On Certainty, framework reading, secular humanism, religious humanism



Apollo Gueco is currently an MA Philosophy student at UP Diliman with a significant primary interest in issues concerning normative concepts (e.g., trust and morality) and theoretical concepts (e.g., scientific or natural kinds). These issues tend to traverse the philosophy of language, epistemology, the philosophy of mind, and the philosophy of science (broadly construed). An always growing secondary interest of his, is in any epistemological or ethical issue the sun shines upon, including religious epistemology. As such, his current thesis proposal is on the concept of trust and the elusive prospects of achieving a definitional consensus in the literature. While I consider myself an agnostic and a religious pluralist, I have been referred to as a theist, given his interest in reading fideist epistemology (I do not mind this at all). In his spare time, he just reads whatever genre of fiction is available to him at the moment.

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A Language Without God: The Agency of Secular Ethics in the Void of the Divine

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Abstract

A Language Without God: The Agency of Secular Ethics in the Void of the Divine

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Here I develop an interrogation of secularization that reconceives the departure from theological dogma not merely as a rationalist triumph over superstition, but as a traumatic confrontation with culture, god, and religion as physical, social forces, of which Lacan calls the grand Autre (Big Other)—the structuring signifier that has historically guaranteed meaning, truth, and moral certainty from a position exterior to human speech. To relinquish God is thus to lose not a belief but a guarantee, and it is this loss that constitutes the properly secular event, rather than any positive achievement of rationality. This is further troubled by the limits of the symbolic order; reading Wittgenstein's propositional boundaries into this collapse, if absolute value belongs, as the Tractatus insists, to the unspeakable domain of the mystical, then the religious language games that once articulated moral certainty were always straining against the limits of propositional sense, rendering their operation in a secular age not merely obsolete but incoherent. Yet, against the anxiety of this unprecedented freedom, society tends to fetishize substitute guarantors—i.e., the State, absolute Reason, or scientific dogmatism. We kill God only to desperately maintain the persistent grammar of theology, re-territorializing the Big Other to foreclose an uncertain future. Against this conservative impulse, I advocate for a destructive secularism capable of generating untimely ethical thinking. By traversing the fantasy of a universal linguistic guarantor, I suggest the possibility of repositioning moral agency entirely within the immanence of human intention, rational planning, and shared reality. In the process, it engenders an emergent secular vocabulary that embraces its own structural contingency, providing a critical pivot for constructing values in a worldview devoid of religion.

Keywords: Secular Humanism, Lacanian Psychoanalysis, Big Other, Moral Agency, Philosophy of Language, Wittgenstein, Nietzsche.



Ron Justin P. Mangondato (RJ) is a philosophy master's student, university lecturer, and research staff member at the Polytechnic University of the Philippines who gets paid to think about things most people actively avoid. He calls himself a generalist, which is academic-speak for refusing to pick a lane—he's convinced the truth only shows up once you stop pretending analytic and continental philosophy are different countries, and he'll happily drag math and science into the argument too. He's also got a soft spot for the occult; his undergrad thesis somehow crammed Hermeticism, the myth of the androgyne, Deleuze, and Simondon into one document, which either makes him a synthesis machine or means his adviser needed a long vacation afterward (he did). These days he's writing on environmental philosophy, the philosophy of ecology, and anthropocentrism, presumably so he can OCD about the planet more rigorously. Religiously, he's a hermetic autotheist, which is basically "I (WE) am my own God" in fancier robes. Off the clock, he devours speculative fiction web serials like Ar'Kendrithyst and Manifold Mirror Mage, geeks out over the lore in Mage: The Ascension, and spends an unreasonable amount of time turtling in Stellaris—because somehow even in space, his first instinct is to build a really solid wall and think it over. "I have an approximate knowledge of many things," - Demon Cat in Adventure Time, Season 2, Episode 2, titled "The Eyes".



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Hyperreal Atheism: The Simulation of God and the Death of Belief

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Abstract

Hyperreal Atheism: The Simulation of God and the Death of Belief

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This paper critically examines the basic tenet of classical atheism and classical theism—that the word "God" refers (or fails to refer) to a real entity whose existence can be accepted or rejected. Based on Jean Baudrillard's theory of simulacra (a copy without an original), this paper proposes an alternative viewpoint—hyperreal atheism—that "God" is a hyperreal simulacrum created within the symbolic orders of language, ritual, art and power—rather than a true or false representation of a divine being. There are three steps detailed in this paper. First, it argues that because classical atheism maintains the theistic presumption that "God" identifies a candidate of existence, it is trapped within the conceptual framework which it aims to reject—making its efforts insufficient. Second, it argues that the question "Does God exist?" is categorically incorrect rather than simply untrue, based on Baudrillard's distinction between simulation and representation—akin to asking "Does Sherlock Holmes live in 221b Baker Street?" Third, it points to the main concern of atheism—if God is a pure simulacrum without original referent, what explains the specific, violent, and persistent content (suffering, sacrifice, absence, hiddenness) rather than any other? The problem presented in this paper is not entirely resolved, instead, it makes the case that—hyperreal atheism is nonetheless intellectually preferable than the passivity of classical atheism as it forgoes the futile endeavor of refuting God in favor of a more fruitful intellectual approach. This paper argues that the proper reaction should be analysis rather than belief or disbelief, asking the questions, such as: How does the simulacrum of God work? What desires does it capture? Whose interests does it serve? This paper concludes that hyperreal atheism turns philosophy of religion from a debate of existence into a study of simulation.

Keywords: Hyperreal atheism, Baudrillard, simulacrum, philosophy of religion, post-atheism



Jhun William T. Cabrezos is currently taking his MA in Philosophy at the Polytechnic University of the Philippines – Sta. Mesa. He is a graduate of the Bachelor of Secondary Education program at PNU-Manila; his thesis was focused on teaching Introduction to Philosophy during the pandemic. He considers himself a devil's advocate as a writer and theorist. The sole purpose of his writing is to speculate about reality grounded in theory. He is devoted to ruthless critique and driven by my personal service to philosophical inquiry in all facets of my experience, which I unapologetically integrate. He makes video essays on YouTube (@wcabrezos) on philosophy and theory for pure intellectual stimulation (fun), as well as writing essays and poetry through Medium (wcabrezos.medium.com). He is an atheist, but he is fascinated by how religion is able to simulate complex human desires and social constructs, rather than exerting all his efforts to debunk the existence of God. Currently, he is pursuing research on Theory-Fiction and how to Filipinize it. He teaches at Cambridge IGCSE Global Perspectives at Singapore School Manila.



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"I Want Knowledge, Not Faith!": Epistemic Undetermination and the Search for the Divine in Ingmar Bergman's The Seventh Seal

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Abstract

"I Want Knowledge, Not Faith!": Epistemic Undetermination and the Search for the Divine in Ingmar Bergman's The Seventh Seal

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Independent Scholar (BS Psychology)
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Widely regarded as one of the greatest films ever made, Ingmar Bergman's The Seventh Seal (1957) is an exploration of the human condition and the quest for answers about life and faith. While most analyses and literature concerning the film are centered on existential dread and the inevitability of mortality, this paper argues that through the lens of religious epistemology, Bergman's primary concern is not the ontological question of God's existence, but rather the epistemic question of what constitutes as valid evidence for the existence of such transcendent reality, staging an investigation on how human beings attempt to justify claims about the "divine" in an epistemically undetermined world, defined as a situation in which the available evidence is compatible with multiple competing explanations and therefore cannot, by itself, determine which explanation is correct. This will be accomplished through a comparative analysis of the film's characters and their beliefs, with which Bergman constructed an ecosystem of different ways of knowing. Such beliefs include: Antonius Block's rational evidentialism against Jof's subjective mystical visions, the Church's projected prophesy of an apocalyptic wrath, Jöns' radical empiricism, the condemned witch's claims of demonic communion, and Death's affirmation of the non-existence of metaphysical divinations beyond mortality. Bergman deconstructs each of these beliefs without giving objective priority to any single framework, leaving every event open to religious, psychological, or existential interpretation. Hence, this paper concludes that The Seventh Seal offers a secular turn: because metaphysical certainty remains fundamentally unattainable, human beings must ground truth and meaning in immanent, shared human experiences rather than elusive signs from above.

Keywords: Film; Faith; Knowledge; Religious Epistemology; Existentialism



Isiah "Seya" Austin Angco is a third-year BS Psychology major from the University of the Philippines Diliman. Aside from running statistical programs and studying mental constructs, he is particularly interested in how Philosophy and Sociology interact with our daily lives. His reading interests move from East to West, such as Daoist philosophy to the works of Karl Marx. He writes not only to understand ideas, but also to see what happens when those ideas are brought back into ordinary life, having written for his personal writing accounts and for several organizations online. Outside of reading and writing, he is also a member of several organizations both from within and outside the campus, taking on roles and responsibilities to contribute something meaningful to the people around him.



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When God Fell Silent: A Heideggerian Analysis of Nietzsche's 'Death of God'

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Humanists International

Abstract

When God Fell Silent: A Heideggerian Analysis of Nietzsche's 'Death of God'

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A famous dichtum "God is dead!" heralded by the German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, gave voice to the elephant that had long stood silently in the room. That is, the rise of secularism and science made God obsolete as the guarantor of meaning. For Martin Heidegger, however, it announced not merely the disappearance of a God, but the collapse of the horizon and foundation upon which Western civilization has constructed their values, meanings and moral criterion upon.Humanity now finds itself centuries later in the shadow cast by the old ruins of certainty and in the Heideggerian sense, the culmination of the forgetting of Being. This paper then embarks as an examination of Nietzsche's proclamation through a Heideggerian lens, asking what becomes possible, and what becomes dangerous when the highest certainty loses its authority. To do so, the paper is divided into three movements. First, it situates the death of God within the broad framework of Heidegger's critique of Western metaphysics and nihilism. Second, it examines humanity's response to this loss and the vacuum of meaning in which modernity attempts to apotheosize new idols. Finally, the paper returns to Heidegger's notion of Human being as Dasein in confronting this condition. As Dasein is to whom its Being is in question, this capacity allows them to simply not replace one ultimate value with another but rather sustain a critical and questioning relation to what grounds of its own existence. This paper then concludes that through a Heideggerian lens, humanity can confront the abyss of nihilism not to the advent of a new god but through a persistent practice of questioning that resists idolatry and opens the possibility of meaning in a post-religious world.

Keywords : Heidegger, Nihlism, Forgetting of Being, Dasein



Edward Timothy M. Sotto is currently taking his Master of Arts major in Philosophy at the University of Santo Tomas Graduate School. He graduated from University of Santo Tomas last June 2026 with a Bachelor's degree in Philosophy with a thesis focused on a Heideggerian critique of Capitalism and technology. His research interests include but are not limited to Ontology, Philosophy of Language, Continental Philosophy, Ancient Greek, Medieval Philosophy and Filipino Philosophy. He has presented his papers in various universities such as in University of the Philippines, Diliman discussing the role of language – specifically the Filipino language – as a world-forming power and Ateneo de Manila University wherein he discusses authenticity amidst pop culture. Outside of academia, Edward takes passion in the arts as he plays the violin where he took violin lessons in the UST Conservatory of Music - Extension program. He also enjoys creating art through both traditional and digital mediums. Though raised as a devout Catholic, Edward keeps an open mind, preferring to live life affirmatively in which he enjoys learning from various perspectives and cultures.



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"Mapupunta ka nga ba sa Impyerno?": The Notion of Huling Hantungan Through the Lens of Heidegger's Being-toward-Death

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Abstract

“Mapupunta ka nga ba sa Impyerno?”: The Notion of Huling Hantungan Through the Lens of Heidegger’s Being-toward-Death

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This paper argues that awareness of death and uncertainty about one’s huling hantungan shape how individuals understand and live their lives. In the Filipino context, huling hantungan is commonly associated with the final destination of the dead, but it also raises a deeper question that concerns what happens to the person after death. The possibility of an unknown afterlife can generate fear and anxiety, particularly when individuals consider religious ideas concerning the soul, heaven, hell, judgment, and salvation. These beliefs provide ways of interpreting death and the fate that awaits an individual after life. However, the significance of death extends beyond the question of what happens after one dies. It also concerns how the awareness of death affects the way a person experiences and approaches life while still alive. Drawing on Martin Heidegger’s concept of Being-toward-death, this paper examines death as an unavoidable possibility within human existence and argues that awareness of mortality can influence how individuals understand and conduct their lives. Applied to the notion of huling hantungan, this awareness may develop into fear of eternal punishment which motivates individuals to participate in religious practices and to regulate their behavior according to beliefs about what is considered right or wrong. However, the paper examines the tension that arises when religious practices are motivated primarily by fear rather than by a genuine internalization of religious teachings. This tension becomes evident when individuals invoke religious teachings to judge the actions of others while failing to consistently apply the same teachings to themselves. The paper therefore argues that awareness of death can shape human behavior not only through reflection on mortality but also through fear of its perceived consequences. In this sense, huling hantungan becomes significant not only as a question of where one goes after death, but also as a belief that can influence how one chooses to live before death.

Keywords: Huling Hantungan; Being-toward-Death; Death Anxiety; Fear of Hell; Religious Practice; Filipino Culture; Martin Heidegger



Marthie Valdueza is a Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy at the University of the Philippines Los Baños, with research interests in feminist philosophy, epistemology, and philosophy of religion. Her academic interests focus on questions concerning power, knowledge, gender, religion, and how beliefs influence social and political life. She is particularly interested in the works of Miranda Fricker, Catharine MacKinnon, and Heloise, whose philosophical perspectives have shaped her interest in epistemic injustice, feminism, and religious and social thought. She believes in God but maintains a critical stance toward religious practices that impose beliefs on others or use religion to justify judgment and discrimination. Outside academia, she enjoys reading, watching films and series, and hiking.

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Lucidity, Revolt, and Passion: The Absurd Hero as a Secular Blueprint

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HAPI Humanist Alliance Philippines, International
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Abstract

Lucidity, Revolt, and Passion: The Absurd Hero As A Secular Blueprint

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The main thrust of this paper is to provide the concept of Absurd Hero introduced by philosopher Albert Camus in his work entitled The Myth of Sisyphus: And Other Essays, as a new secular blueprint and as a solution for how to deal with a meaningless universe, especially to someone who does not abide by religion or a divine authority. The world right now is divided between believers and seculars, with the former believing in the idea of a divine deity, which is, firstly, a God they chose to worship. Second is that the divine deity serves as their compass for morality – whether an action is justifiable or not in their God's eyes. Lastly, it is the hope that they cling to when life becomes too dreadful. This is the opposite in the life of a secular person, someone who does not abide by divine authority. They are often asked by theists about the basis of their morality, actions, and ethics. How do they deal with life when it comes to confronting the absurdity of the universe? I will answer this question by arranging my paper into three sections. The first section of the paper will introduce the religious framework that is followed by theists and believers, and the prejudice non-believers experience in conservative spaces. The second section will then be a discussion on Albert Camus' Absurd Hero. In this section, I will define the absurd, analyze the concept of philosophical suicide, and lay out the structure of an Absurd Hero. Lastly, the final section of the paper will elucidate how to live as the Absurd Hero in our current society. Living a life not based on divine judgments, and clinging to false hopes to cope with absurdity, but confronting the meaningless universe with fiery passion.

Keywords: Albert Camus, Absurdism, Secular, Divine Authority, Philosophical Suicide



Jason Zachary Tanabe Gayoma is an undergraduate junior student at the Most Royal and Pontifical Catholic University of Santo Tomas - Manila. He is currently pursuing a Bachelor of Arts (A.B.) in Philosophy. He recently finished his secondary school at Manila Tytana Colleges and graduated with an Honors and Recognized Student Officer (RSO) Award, for serving as the Deputy for Chairperson for Programs and Activities (2022-2023), and Deputy for Vice President for Student Affairs (2023-2024) in Manila Tytana Colleges - Senior High School Student Council (SHSC). He continued his dedication and leadership in serving the student body by serving as the Councilor for Socio-Cultural Affairs & Communication (PRO) in Concilium Philosophize - the Official Student Council of AB Philosophy. As of the moment, his research interests are Filipino Philosophy (specifically Florentino Hornedo), Karl Marx, and Albert Camus. In his free time, he also reads Emil Cioran and Jürgen Habermas. He currently enjoys reading, jogging, watching movies, playing eSports, and playing video games in his free time.



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Kapwa And The Ethics Of Responsibility: A Philosophical Understanding Through Gandhi's Dharma

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Abstract

Kapwa And The Ethics Of Responsibility: A Philosophical Understanding Through Gandhi's Dharma

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This study investigates the Filipino Social Philosophy concept of kapwa together with the ethical responsibility through Hindu Dharma thus in creating a comparative philosophical analysis within the works of Virgilio Enriquez and Mahatma Gandhi. Gandhi's reinterpretation of dharma as a dynamic normative order which governs the ethical responsibility in identifying moral agency, obligation, and social engagement with an aim of maintaining equal treatment of others and for others. Enriquez, on the other hand defines kapwa as the "shared inner self" which seeks the relationship of the Filipino people as a whole, and provides an ontological basis for understanding the self as fundamentally relational. This comparative philosophy seeks to investigate the parallels between kapwa in Filipino Philosophy and Hindu dharma in Ghandian philosophy through the shared belief in the unity and equality of all life, translating relational awareness into concrete ethical action. Hence, by creating a cross-cultural examination of the notion "Truth is life" with the "shared identity," the boundaries of the self and others are abolished. Ultimately, this study argues that both frameworks are used in pursuit of liberated ethics of solidarity rooted in ahimsa (non-violence) and the recognition of the Divine, offering a path toward social justice and universal humanitarianism which further seeks to establish a moral compass and a dynamic normative order to which pagkatao (personhood) and the practice of dharma as the karma (action) are dedicated in line with the service of others and for others, proposing an ethics of responsibility that emphasizes mutual recognition, compassion, and accountability towards others.



Christian Johan T. Perez is a junior Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy student at the Polytechnic University of the Philippines. He is currently working on a research project that develops a cross-cultural analysis of Filipino Philosophy's concept of kapwa and Gandhi's Hindu dharma. His academic interests include Eastern Philosophy, Marxism, Phenomenology, and Existentialism. His religious and philosophical views are shaped by a continuous interest in exploring existence, the meaning of life, and human understanding. Outside academia, he enjoys engaging in philosophical discussions on religion and culture, going on spontaneous trips with his friends, and playing golf and pickleball with his family.

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Kiat: An Existential Reflection of Trans Filipinx Becoming as a Movement

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Abstract

Kiat: An Existential Reflection of Trans Filipinx Becoming as a Movement

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Stryker describes trans as a movement across a socially imposed boundary away from an unchosen starting place. For the Bisayang Trans Filipinx, trans philosophy not only assumes their epistemic reliability in understanding trans phenomena but also obligates the appraisal of trans theories within their existential milieu. In light of this, I propose kiat as a decolonized conceptual tool that situates the movement declared by Stryker within Trans Filipinx becoming. I utilize a wealth of trans literature to create a transpositive existential reflection of the term, which stratified into three main themes. First, Kiat as profane is used to analyze how the trans Filipinx is pre situated in a primarily religious, gender-essentialist world that restricts trans extension, and unpacks this world as historical, not predestined. Second, Kiat as restless takes the transphobic world as a stimulus for the oppositional movement of transitioning bodies, understanding what it means to undertake a free and authentic becoming. Lastly, Kiat as playful reflects on the temporality of this movement, criticizing transnormativity and trans exceptionalism, and imagines how play has been an alternative kind of bearing-with embodied by trans Filipinxs. In conclusion, this paper takes advantage of kiat's equivocal nature to offer a more nuanced and situated appraisal of Stryker's theory. The findings can be used to engage in critical dialogue with other trans philosophies, with the broader aim of further illuminating the WTF of trans life and the praxis of trans liberation.

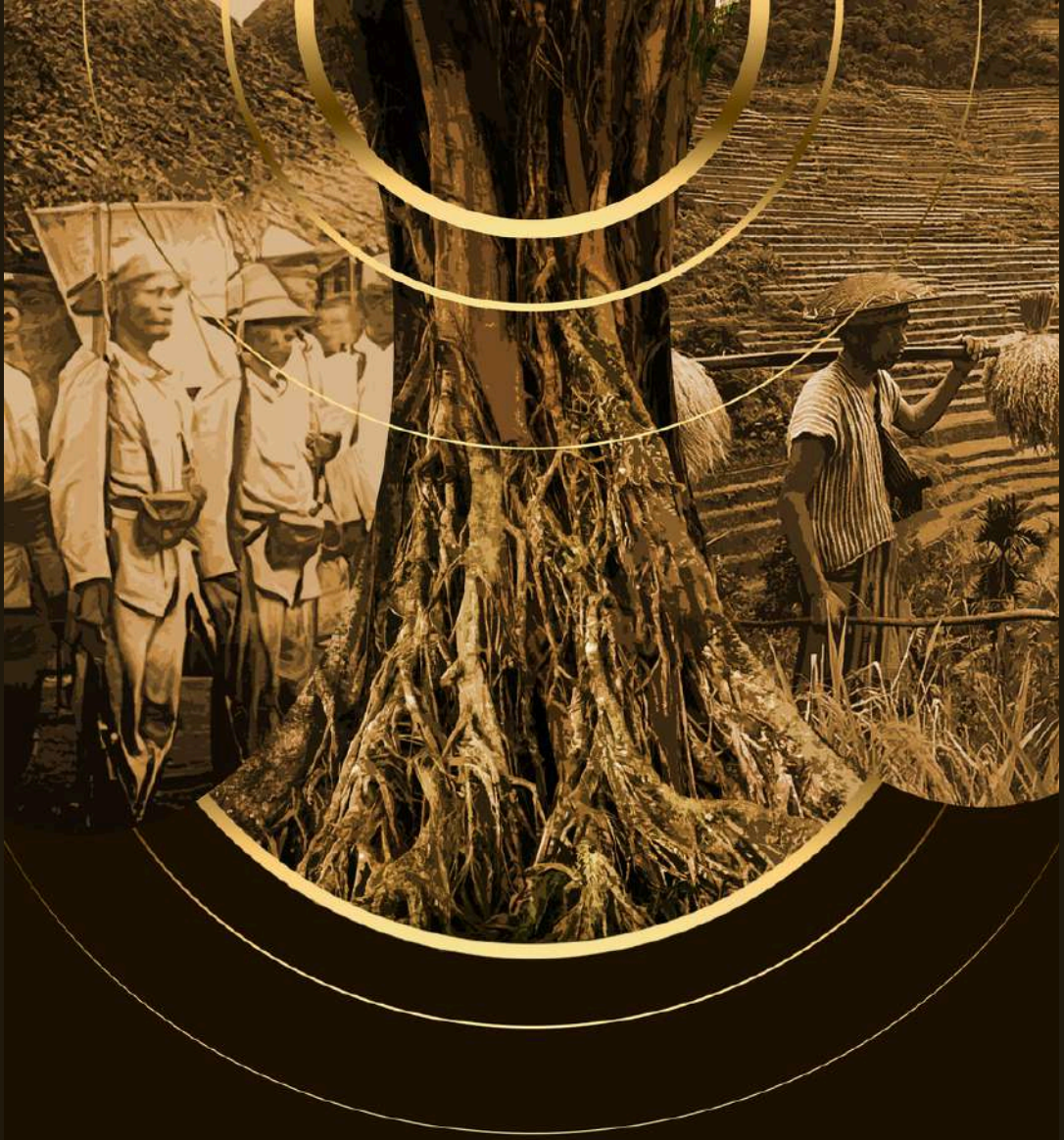
Keywords: kiat, transgender philosophy, transgender existentialism, decolonizing



Kane Gaviola is an agnostic, transpinay, undergraduate student from the Polytechnic University of the Philippines, under the program AB Philosophy. She is a long-time member of Kasarianlan, the university's premier LGTBQIA+ organization. Her academic interests lie in Transgender Philosophy, Queer Phenomenology, and Environmental Humanities. She experienced her first paper presentation just this October during the 1st GAD Student Conference in UP Diliman, where she presented her undergraduate thesis. She enjoys distracting her anxieties with video games and walks in nature. Currently in her fourth year, she aims to expand her scholarship into a broader praxis, guided by the existential drive towards illuminating what Bettcher calls the WTF of trans life. Of course, intending to branch towards other marginalized human and non-human lives at large.

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Ang Abat sa Balete ug ang Ginoo (The Phantom of the Balete Tree and God): Biopolitics, CounterGeographies and the Waning of Ecclesiastical Control in the Phantom's Domain

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Abstract

Ang Abat sa Balete ug ang Ginoo (The Phantom of the Balete Tree and God): Biopolitics, Counter-Geographies and the Waning of Ecclesiastical Control in the Phantom's Domain

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Are non-corporeal entities evil, or was their demonization a tool of territorial control? Filipinos have always lived with and by nature, maintaining deep respect for the landscape and its inhabitants. The introduction of religion altered this relationship, as colonies used institutional religion to discipline space. In Philippine history, Spanish Catholic evangelization operationalized control via the doctrine of bajo el son de la campana (under the sound of the bell), mapping moral order onto domesticated terrain while systematically demonizing untamed landscapes. Nonetheless, spaces like the balete tree remain untouched by clerical control. While colonial theology worships a transcendent moral god, these ancient trees—revered as habitats for unseen entities and thresholds to other worlds—continue to command quiet, autonomous respect. This paper argues that the phantom's domain functions as a resilient counter-geography that marks the limits of Catholic spatial biopolitics. Utilizing Michel Foucault's theories of spatial biopolitics alongside Giorgio Agamben's construct of the state of exception, I contend that Visayan folk animism offers a functional, proto-secular framework of spatial governance operating entirely independent of a moral deity. Against claims that folk beliefs represent backward theological vestiges requiring erasure by organized religion or technocratic rationalism, this paper demonstrates that this indigenous counter-geography successfully enforces ecological boundaries and spatial ethics without relying on dogmatic scripture. Ultimately, I argue that the fading grip of centralized divine authority does not produce spatial or moral chaos, but rather reveals an enduring, autonomous, and non-theistic ethics.

Keywords: spatial biopolitics, counter-geographies, visayan folk animism, non-theistic ethics, state of exception



Hannah Valerie Acama is a 4th year BS Philosophy student at Mindanao State University–Iligan Institute of Technology (MSU-IIT), where her primary research interests include women's studies, applied ethics, biopolitics, indigenous studies and language. Her current thesis delves into local shamans in her community called 'mananambals' to understand the existence of their non-corporeal companion, the Abyan who guides themes in healing, seeing visions and communicating with the Spirit world. Beyond her academic work, Valerie is a passionate advocate for VAWC Awareness, Indigenous Peoples' Rights and actively participates in community-driven initiatives. Off the clock, she finds balance through creative projects, volunteer activities, and taking time to enjoy local culture. Philosophically, she approaches the world through a grounded existential-phenomenological lens, viewing human existence as an ongoing journey of questioning, learning, and relational ethics. Ultimately, she considers herself a lifelong learner who is always eager to engage in meaningful conversations both inside and outside the classroom.

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